6 LINES FOR THE DEMO WHERE THE BUILD IS GOOD AND THE THING IS WRONG

What to say when the engineer built the wrong thing

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

1 Say what is good in one line, then stop

A compliment that runs long tells them the next part is bad. One line, then the thing.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Great work, this looks really clean, I love the animation, super fast too."
> Instead say: "Nice, it's fast. One thing."

Praise gets one sentence. The thing gets the rest.

2 Name the user it fails, not the feature

Say who cannot do their job with this build. A person, not a requirement.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Can we tweak the filter a bit?"
> Instead say: "An admin can't find their own team with this. That's the main use."

If you can't name the person it fails, you are not sure it's wrong yet.

3 Ask how it got here before you say wrong

Half the time the build matches a spec you wrote. Find out before you call it a miss.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "This isn't what we agreed."
> Instead say: "Walk me through what you built it from."

Ask first. You might be the one who was wrong.

4 Give the fix a size and a date

Vague asks turn into another wrong build. Say what changes and when it's due.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Whenever you get a chance, can you fix it?"
> Instead say: "Swap the filter to team name. Can that be done Thursday?"

A fix without a date is a wish.

5 Put the decision on the table: fix or ship

Sometimes shipping the wrong thing on time beats fixing it late. Make that a choice, out loud.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "We have to fix this before launch."
> Instead say: "Fix it Thursday, or ship as is and fix next sprint? Your call on effort, mine on risk."

Say the two options and who owns which part.

6 When it was your spec that was wrong

This is the one on page 2. If the build matches what you wrote, say so first, before any fix.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "The spec was a bit unclear, sorry about that."
> Instead say: "You built what I wrote. I wrote the wrong thing. Here's the change, and it's on me with your lead."

Own it in one sentence, then move to the fix. Nobody respects the second apology.

Check before you say it

- [ ] Did the praise get one sentence?
- [ ] Can you name the person the build fails?
- [ ] Did you ask what they built it from?
- [ ] Does the fix have a size and a day?
- [ ] Did you say fix or ship, and who decides?